GLASSHOUSE

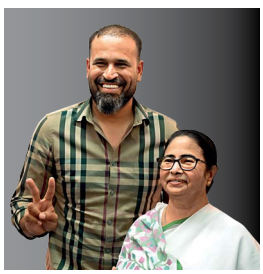
SONIA'S SURPRISE

On March 12, the Congress released its second list of candidates for the general election, and sources say the main tussle was for the Nagaon constituency in Assam. Gaurav Gogoi, son of ex-CM Tarun Gogoi, wanted to contest from the Muslim-majority seat. His current constituency, Kaliabor, has not only been renamed Kaziranga but delimitation has altered its geography and demography. Thanks to his proximity to Rahul Gandhi, Gaurav was almost certain and had even stationed his team in Nagaon. However, the plan came a cropper, thanks to Sonia Gandhi's last-minute intervention. She backed sitting MP Pradyut Bordoloi for the seat and asked Gaurav to fight from Jorhat, which hasn't voted Congress since 2014. Interestingly, Bordoloi had supported Shashi Tharoor when the latter had contested against the party-backed Mallikarjun Kharge for the Congress president's post.



Illustration by **SIDDHANT JUMDE**

OUTSIDE INFLUENCE



West Bengal CM **Mamata Banerjee's** "*bohiragoto*" or outsider jibe at BJP leaders is coming back to bite her. In the TMC list of Lok Sabha candidates released on February 10, at least three nominees—cricketers **Yusuf Pathan** and Kirti Azad, and veteran actor Shatrughan Sinha—are not Bengalis. The move has given the BJP a chance to hit back at the TMC, unravelling the "hypocrisy" of Bengal's incumbent rulers. It remains unclear why the TMC, in spite of its brute majority in the assembly, needed to depend on star power from outside Bengal for the parliamentary polls.

WELCOME KIT

The Grand Old Party is really having a tough time of it in heartland state Madhya Pradesh. What began with Jyotiraditya Scindia in March 2020 continues with the latest deserter, former Union minister Suresh Pachauri, who joined the BJP on March 9. There are others, including an ex-CM, who almost joined but have not, at least for now. The rush to join is such that the BJP has created a special call, the 'New Joining Cell' headed by former state home minister **Narottam Mishra**. The cell coordinates the welcome wagon, including press meet, garlands and other paraphernalia. Needless to say, in the run-up to the Lok Sabha election, the cell is working overtime.



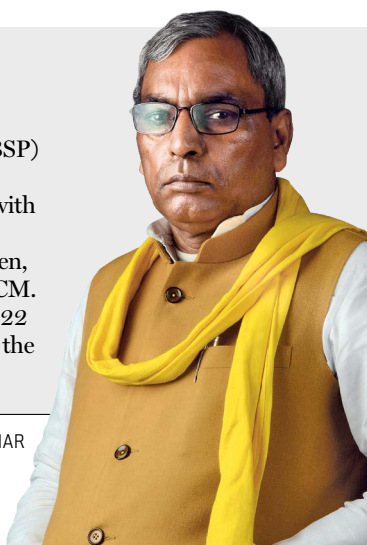
Ode to Shiva



Amruta Fadnavis is already known for her singing, but her husband and Maharashtra deputy CM **Devendra Fadnavis** can also carry a tune. The latter recently turned lyricist, too, composing a devotional song to Lord Shiva, 'Devadhi Dev'. Released on March 6, two days before Maha Shivratri, the song has vocals by Amruta and Grammy winner **Shankar Mahadevan**.

HIGH ON EMPOWERMENT

Just two days into his innings as a cabinet minister in the Uttar Pradesh government and Suheldev Bharatiya Samaj Party (SBSP) chief **Om Prakash Rajbhar** has already got CM Yogi Adityanath squirming. On March 7, during a visit to Mau, an eastern district with substantial Rajbhar voters, he told party workers to ensure police officers "listened to them politely" since he was now a minister. Then, he claimed he was the most powerful person in the state after the CM. Incidentally, this is the same Rajbhar who, in the run-up to the 2022 assembly polls, had said that he would send Yogi "running back to the temple" (the latter is the mahant of the Gorakhnath math).



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

Kaushik Deka with Afrida Hussain, Rahul Noronha, Arkamoy Datta Majumdar, Dhaval S. Kulkarni and Ashish Misra